

Question 1: Credit

"I wanted to tell them that, in Kabul, we snapped a tree branch and used it as a credit card. Hassan and I would take the wooden stick to the bread maker. He'd carve notches on our stick with his knife, one notch for each loaf of *naan* he'd pull for us from the *tandoor*'s roaring flames. At the end of the month, my father paid him for the number of notches on the stick. That was it. No questions. No ID." (128)

1. Why are they able to use this kind of system of accounting in Kabul? What makes it possible there and impossible in America? Trust? Social cohesion? Custom? Tradition? Different kind of economy?
2. Which system strikes you as better — using a wooden stick with notches or asking for ID for a check? Why?

Question 2: Baba's party

We took a seat at the bar, next to an old man, his leathery face sickly in the blue glow of the Michelob sign overhead. Baba lit a cigarette and ordered us beers. "Tonight I am too much happy," he announced to no one and everyone. "Tonight I drinking with my son. And one, please, for my friend," he said, patting the old man on the back. The old fellow tipped his hat and smiled. He had no upper teeth.

Baba finished his beer in three gulps and ordered another. He had three before I forced myself to drink a quarter of mine. By then he had bought the old man a scotch and treated a foursome of pool players to a pitcher of Budweiser. Men shook his hand and clapped him on the back. They drank to him. Someone lit his cigarette. Baba loosened his tie and gave the old man a handful of quarters. He pointed to the jukebox. "Tell him to play his favorite songs," he said to me. The old man nodded and gave Baba a salute. Soon, country music was blaring, and, just like that, Baba had started a party. (132)

1. What does this scene reveal about Baba's personality? Do you know anyone like this?

Question 3: Visiting

Consider how the narrator visits Soraya's stand every weekend for almost a year before working up the nerve to talk to her (144). Soraya notices him each time but does not talk to him either. Do you think his visiting her for a year helped him get close to her when he finally did talk to her?

Question 4: Secrets

After Soraya tells the narrator what happened to her when she was 18, the narrator says "I envied her. Her secret was out. Spoken. Dealt with. I opened my mouth and almost told her how I'd betrayed Hassan, lied, driven him out, and destroyed a forty-year relationship between Baba and Ali. But I didn't. I suspected there were many ways in which Soraya Taheri was a better person than me. Courage was just one of them." (165)

1. Why does the narrator envy Soraya? Why might envy be his first emotion rather than feeling for Soraya?
2. What is the "courage" that the narrator is talking about? Does it take courage to talk about your secrets?
3. The narrator says "how could I, of all people, chastise someone for the past?" after hearing of Soraya's past. How might the narrator's own guilt help him be less judgmental of others?

Question 5: Character Analysis

Consider the description of Soraya's father in pages 176-179. What kind of person does he strike you as? Compare and contrast with Baba.